

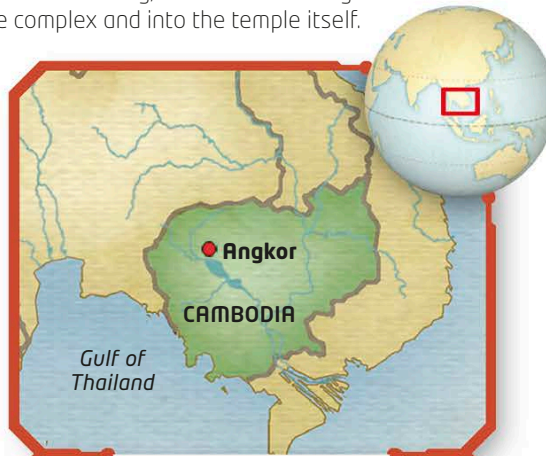
KHMER CAPITAL

Today partly hidden by lush forests, the ancient city of Angkor was once a mighty capital of the Khmer Empire. It was a vast network of temple compounds, palaces, villages, and waterways. Over time, any wooden buildings vanished, leaving behind only gigantic stone temples.

Gold objects, such as this pin, were inlaid with precious gemstones.

Ring of gold adorned with a pearl

1 The bridge across the moat becomes a raised walkway, which leads through the complex and into the temple itself.



Fertile region

Angkor is in northern Cambodia, in Asia. It is surrounded by forests and farmland. Many rivers flow through this area, watering its many rice plantations.

Buddhist pilgrimage site

For centuries, Angkor's rulers prayed to Hindu gods, but in the late 13th century, Buddhism grew in importance. The site began to attract Buddhists from across Asia, as well as Zhou Daguan, a Chinese diplomat who wrote a book about Angkor.

Golden empire

The Khmer Empire was very wealthy. Its kings would wear a golden crown, bracelets around their wrists and ankles, and rings on fingers and toes. It was powerful, too—by the 12th century, the Khmers ruled a huge area of southeast Asia.



Buddhist pilgrims undertake long journeys for their spiritual development.

Giant stone faces decorate the walls of the Bayon Temple in Angkor Thom.

Angkor Thom

In the late 12th century, King Jayavarman VII began building himself a new city complex within Angkor, calling it Angkor Thom. He kept some older temples within his city walls and built a few new ones, including the Bayon.

Nature takes over

In the 15th century, Angkor stopped being the capital of the Khmer Empire and the royals left. It was not abandoned, but fell into decline. Plants slowly grew over parts of the city.

